Look, Shooting Stars

I fall backward, the streetlights streaking across my vision like shooting stars.

I used to wonder whether, to see shooting stars, you really had to wait somewhere under a clear night sky for a celestial body to hurtle toward Earth. I thought that if we ran toward the stars, they would be moving relative to us, too. Then all I would have to do was look up to see a shooting star—something I still haven't seen.

So I imagined an open field beneath the stars, where I could run through the wild grass toward the night sky. I would look up and see the stars generously spilling their impossibly romantic light into the long trails I had only ever seen on a screen. Unfortunately, I hardly ever had the chance to try this foolish experiment. The city had stolen all the stars of my childhood. Where there were open fields, there were no stars; where there were stars, I was in the deep woods back home. And there, running was sure to end with me falling headlong over some tree stump that had grown tired of watching shooting stars.

Now I know that the only way to see shooting stars is to be in the right place at the right time. You need to happen to be somewhere without too much light pollution just when a group of celestial bodies happens to plunge into Earth's atmosphere, bent on self-destruction.

Running toward the night sky clearly won't produce anything resembling shooting stars. If it could, passengers in cars and high-speed trains would only have to look up at a starry sky to see even lovelier ones. The reason is simple: people, and everything people have made, move far too slowly compared with the stars.

These days, we can predict most of those chance moments weeks in advance, and work out where to see them. So I think that when I have time, I'll take a high-speed train or catch a flight and go chasing a meteor shower.

"When we have time," I say to Xia Housheng, turning toward him as though we are making a proper plan.

Some promises have a definite time and place as soon as they are spoken. Others have only hope. Those beginning with these words tend to be the latter. I know we probably won't have time to see a meteor shower. Even if we do, we might no longer be this close by then. Even if we have both, and actually set off for Reykjavík or some other place famous for shooting stars, we won't be going to fulfill the promise we are making so casually now. At that time, we might finish the whole trip without once remembering this evening.

I have made promises like this, more wishes than promises, with many friends. I'm no longer in touch with most of them.

Xia Housheng has heard more of them than anyone. We're still in touch. We still sometimes take walks on an abandoned rooftop beneath the night sky.

Sometimes he says he wants to go too, with an enthusiasm that matches mine. That enthusiasm comes easily, because we both know we will never set off.

Today he doesn't join in. Strict chinese boarding schools have worn us both down so much that we rarely have the energy to summon even this kind of careless enthusiasm.

"It'll be hard to find the time."

In his tired voice, the uneasy truth we both know sounds perfectly ordinary.

"After high school there's college, and after college…"

I nod and begin complaining in the same anxious tone. We share the jumble of things weighing on us. The pressure of what lies ahead always makes us turn and look back. I think this is one of the main reasons we reminisce.

Suddenly I remember a notebook I found while tidying up at home this morning. It's the kind with a combination lock that was popular when I was in elementary school, with over-the-top designs printed on the cover. I bought lots of them.

I remember very clearly setting every one of them to 525. The combination on my suitcase is one I chose back then, too. It's also 525. I remember why just as clearly. My mother was keen on teaching me to love myself around that time. On May 25, she told me it was a day worth celebrating more than May 20: in Chinese, 525 sounds like "I love myself," and 520 like "I love you." We should love ourselves first. Without quite realizing it, I began setting all sorts of three- and six-digit codes to repetitions of 525.

"If you ever find my suitcase, go ahead and try 525. See if it opens," I joke.

"Sure. If it does, the most you're getting back is the empty case."

As I write this, a thought suddenly occurs to me: if, years from now, you've read this piece and happen to find my suitcase, could you remember this passage, enter those numbers, and actually open it? The thought makes me laugh for no particular reason. Who would remember some odd passage in this awkward, youthful piece for years, then happen to recognize me somewhere and find a bag I'd left behind?

What I want to say is, my friend, if that day ever comes, please help yourself to the suitcase. You don't even have to return the empty case. Please take every last thing inside. If I can, I'll give you every suitcase I ever come to own. I can already tell there won't be gold or silver or treasure inside, but please don't turn them down. Anyone who remembers all this deserves them.

We climb onto the abandoned rooftop, a pocket-sized open field in the city. The late-autumn dandelions have lost their white fluff. If we hadn't been here that spring, I

would take them for some nameless weeds. I think of the deep woods back home. Dandelions like these grow on the cliff face there, too. There, the universe's breath flickers in and out of sight.

The airport in S City was built close to the city center—so close that people often say it has kept the city from spreading any farther. You can often see planes crossing the night like shooting stars. Overhead. In the pitch-black sky, the only things shining are high-rises, streetlights, and planes. We can't even see stars, let alone shooting stars. The vast city steals the stars by shining more brightly than they do, and by keeping us rushing through our lives on the ground until we forget to look up at the night sky now and then, hoping for stars.

Leaving the rooftop, we return to our lives on the ground and head home. Planes cross the night like shooting stars. I look up.

Then I fall. I suppose I caught my foot on something when I forgot to look down. Solid, hard, silent, like a tree stump in the deep woods that has grown tired of watching shooting stars. Xia Housheng tells me later that it was the stone bollard by the entrance.

I fall backward. The streetlamps lining the road and the scattered lights in people's homes sweep forward in an arc. I see cometlike curves of light, brightness and darkness alternating in the blink of an eye.

I get up and tap his shoulder, then sweep a finger along the buildings lining the street: windows lit yellow, lit white, curtains drawn tight, windows dark.

I take out my camera, set a long exposure, press the shutter, and swing it sideways. The light traces the arcs I saw a moment ago across the frame. Those colors are caught in a single photograph. Time has drawn them out into tails.

"Look. Shooting stars." I show Xia Housheng the photograph.

"We have time now," I say, smiling. We walk on, becoming part of the starry sky here on earth.